



JAMHURI DAY

Tourism agenda

New tourism initiatives reflect a drive to deepen the sector's contribution to economic growth and, therefore, the country's sovereignty

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TOURISM

State initiatives give tourism sector a lift

New tourism agenda reflects a drive to deepen the sector’s contribution to economic growth and, therefore, the country’s sovereignty

The Government has stepped up efforts to rejuvenate the tourism industry, with various initiatives unveiled in the past months tying into making the sector a great contributor to economic growth.

And as we celebrate Kenya as a Republic this Jamhuri Day, whose theme is Tourism, Wildlife and Meetings, Incentives, Conferences and Exhibitions (MICE), the new tourism agenda reflects a drive to deepen the sector’s contribution to economic growth and, therefore, our sovereignty.

President William Ruto on Tuesday unveiled a plan to construct five high-end hotels in Tsavo West National Park, an initiative that is expected to raise the number of visitors going to the park. The President said the new hotels are part of the broader strategy to elevate Kenya’s wildlife tourism offerings and strengthen conservation financing. He further launched the world’s largest rhino sanctuary, a vast 3,200-square-kilometre wildlife protection area in Tsavo West.

The development of the sanctuary is another milestone in Kenya’s conservation efforts, as the facility will expand rhino habitats, encourage breeding and protect them from poachers, boosting their population.

Other key Government initiatives that have lifted tourism include the Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) system, which was started in January 2024.

The system has cut the processing time of visitors from up to 14 days to less than 72 hours. ETA is credited for supporting over 1.8 million applications in its first year, with the platform improving security through real-time traveller screening and digital travel credentials. The

Economic Survey 2025 credits ETA for the rise in the number of international visitors in 2024 to 2.4 million, up from 2.1 million in 2023.

The winning of the bid to host CHAN 2024 alongside Uganda and Tanzania came as a boost to Kenya’s tourism sector.

In the build-up to the month-long football fiesta, which kicked off in August this year, the Government had invested some Sh57 billion to construct and rehabilitate key sports facilities in preparation for the games. Thousands of football fans, as well as players, trooped into the country during the football period, with the tourism sector in particular hotels, reaping from boom.

Away from the direct benefit, Kenya received free publicity as the global spotlight shone on Kenya. The country was, therefore, able to showcase its tourism delicacies including the wildlife and Sandy beaches. Another sporting event that drew thousands of visitors and offered Kenya free marketing is the WRC Safari Rally which happened in March.

At least 39 ace drivers battled for the top spot in the rugged Naivasha terrain, where they navigated rocky roads, sandy tracks and water crossings in a contest between, man, machine and nature. As the drivers sweated it out, the global cameras and rally lovers were able to sample out wildlife and other delicacies offered.

The unveiling of the nine tourism circuits by the Kenya Tourism Board (KTB) in 2024 under the Tembea Kenya initiative has come as a huge boost to the sector.

These circuits, notes KTB Chief Executive Officer June Chepkemei, have helped to elevate Kenya’s tourism offerings by highlighting undiscovered gems.

The circuits have helped travellers to explore the full diversity of our country’s breathtaking landscapes, culture and wildlife.

“We are excited to introduce these circuits as part of our ongoing efforts to diversify Kenya’s tourism appeal. These circuits not only showcase the best of Kenya but also provide an opportunity for inclusive growth, ensuring tourism benefits reach every corner of our beautiful country,” said Ms Chepkemei.



President William Ruto launches the expanded Tsavo West Rhino Sanctuary in Ngulia, Taita Taveta on Tuesday. It is now the world’s largest rhino conservation sanctuary at 3,200sq km.

The Kenya National Tourism Strategy 2025-2030, developed by the Ministry of Tourism and Wildlife, is designed to expand the industry beyond the traditional beaches and safari offerings to include cultural, wellness, sports, adventure, agritourism and MICE tourism.

The Government has further streamlined compensation to victims of human-wildlife conflict to ensure prompt payment as part of efforts to boost conservation.

President Ruto said Kenyans will no longer wait for up to eight years to be compensated under the revised scheme and pointed out that the

Government has paid Sh2.7 billion as well as increased allocations for compensation. “We want to ensure Kenyans are paid within the shortest time possible. This is why we have migrated the scheme from a manual to a digital platform,” President Ruto said. The Government has further moved to revamp Magical Kenya campaign, under which it has marketed the country for the last 15 years.

Tourism and Wildlife CS Rebecca Miano constituted a 23-member taskforce to audit the current brand, assess how Kenya is perceived globally and benchmark against leading destinations like Tanzania, Rwanda and Mauritius, which have invested heavily in promotional strategies.

The Government is further promoting MICE to attract five million international visitors per year by 2030. In a five-year strategy, the Ministry has proposed partnerships with global event organisers to boost the sector and hopes to Position Kenya as a premier MICE hub in

Africa. The strategic actions are anchored on the National MICE Strategy 2024 - 2028, which proposes among other things enactment of a National MICE policy and re-establishment of Kenya National Convention Bureau that should be fully empowered to coordinate, plan, promote and regulate the sector across national and county levels.

The strategy further proposes the establishment of Regional Visitor and Convention Bureaus (CVBs) in key MICE destinations in Nairobi, Mombasa, Naivasha, Nakuru, Nanyuki and Kisumu. Nairobi has hosted major conferences in the past months, including Africa MICE Summit and the COMESA Summit. With thousands of delegates attending the events, MICE offer a promising future for Kenya’s tourism. Tourism PS John Olotuaa said to promote the sector, Government investments will focus on venues and infrastructure, improved air connectivity, competitive bidding frameworks, digital platforms and sustainability guidelines for green meetings. ■

From three rhinos 40 years ago, the Tsavo West Rhino Sanctuary has advanced into a national and global treasure.



MANAGEMENT

Kajiado takes over Amboseli park



TRAINING

Utalii leads the way

REPUBLIC

Jamhuri Day: The history, from struggle to sovereignty

The story of resilience and sacrifice, where the fight for freedom blossomed into the pride of nationhood

Kenya's journey to self-governance and an independent State recognised by the Community of Nations was long and torturous, starting from 1880s where the country was part of the British East Africa Protectorate

Our forefathers resisted the annexation of their land, forced labour and taxation, birthing a struggle which created heroes, heroines and martyrs.

The pioneer champions of Kenya's struggle for independence were Koitalel Arap Samoei who spearheaded a 10-year rebellion in Rift Valley, Waiyaki wa Hinga, Mekatilili wa Menza and Moraa wa Ngiti. By the time Kenya became a proper colony in 1920, citizens freedoms of movement and association had been limited to an extent that even in the staff quarters in colonial plantations, workers were housed according to their tribes and strictly prohibited from mixing with colleagues from other communities.

Even though Africans were heavily taxed, the Colonial Government invested very little in their education as it had left Missionaries to establish and run their own schools, which frowned upon technical subjects.

Schools were supposed to create a labour pool of artisans and clerical officers. Historian Martin Meredith in his book, *The State of Africa* captures the attitude of the colonial masters towards education. He writes that by 1910, there were 16,000 missionaries in the whole of Africa, who established a handful of secondary schools that served as nurseries for new African elites.

These punitive policies such as the requirement that Africans obtain a special pass (Kipande) and



Mzee Jomo Kenyatta, then serving as a Prime Minister, with Malcolm MacDonald, Governor General of Nairobi and other leaders on December 12, 1964 Jamhuri Day.

special permission before travelling or staying in such places as Nairobi fuelled discontent that snowballed into armed struggle and riots, which ultimately led to mass arrests, detention and killing following the declaration of the State of Emergency in October, 1952.

This was triggered by the killing of Paramount Chief Waruhiu Kungu of Kiambu leading to the arrest on October 20, 1952 of all people perceived as Mau Mau leaders and sympathisers. Among those netted in Operation Jock Stock were Jomo Kenyatta, Paul Ngei, Bildad Kaggia, Ramogi Achieng Onoko, Fred Kubai and Kungu Karumba.

The results was a decade of anarchy and political instability during which 14,000 Africans, 29 Asians and 95 settlers died, according to Charles Hornsby's *Kenya: A history Since Independence*.

The British Government caved in and allowed Africans to elect their leaders, some of whom had been jailed or detained, in readiness for granting the country self-governance on June 1, 1963, a day we currently celebrate as Madaraka Day.

But Madaraka Day should not be confused with Jamhuri Day. The two represent different stages in the country's journey to sovereignty.

While during Jamhuri Day we celebrate Kenya's full independence and transition into a Republic, on Madaraka Day, we commemorate our attainment of internal self-rule.

Jamhuri Day was first celebrated in Kenya on December 12, 1964 while Madaraka Day on June 1, 1963.

Hornsby captures the precise moment the Union Jack was lowered shortly before midnight on December 11, 1963, to the roaring jubilation of 250,000 Kenyans who watched as

Duke of Edinburgh Duncan Sandys, the then Colonial Secretary received the flag from Prime Minister Jomo Kenyatta. At the time, Kenya had only 1,800 kilometres of tarmacked road, 250,000 job opportunities in public, industrial and plantation sectors and slightly over 200,000 secondary school learners and an estimated 800,000 students in primary schools.

Today, there are 3.4 million Kenyans in formal employment while 17.4 million are in informal employment, according to the Kenya National Bureau of Statistics (KNBS).

Similarly, the number of primary school children has risen from the 800,000 in 1963 to 10.4 million in both public and private institutions.

An estimated 4 million students are in secondary schools, with the rapid growth attributed to the introduction of Free Primary Education by the

Government in 2002.

In the university sector, the number of students and institutions has increased from one public university - the University of Nairobi, and a single private university (USIU) in 1970, to over 75 currently.

On the political front, the country has almost gone full circle, with the two Chamber Parliamentary system, multiparty politics and a devolved system of Government created by the Lancaster House Constitution is now in place even though with slight variations.

For instance, at independence, the Prime Minister was the Head of Executive while the Senate was the Upper House and devolved units were headed by regional presidents.

As we celebrate Jamhuri Day, let us not forget sacrifices made in the past and our progress today. Let's move together into the future with unity. ■

TOURISM

THE SITES

Top tourists attractions to visit as the holiday season sets in

From Nairobi National Park to Maasai Mara Game Reserve and the sandy beaches at the Coast, Kenya is endowed with many tourists attractions

Kenya has several globally acclaimed tourist sites, which draw millions of visitors each year by offering a rich blend of wildlife, breathtaking landscapes and scenic beaches. From the glamorous Maasai Mara to the sandy beaches of Diani, the country's tourist attractions showcase why Kenya remains one of favourite leading travel destinations. Here is a sample of the major tourism attractions in each of the country's eight administrative regions which you should purpose to visit this festive season:

Nairobi

Nairobi National Park stands out globally as the only game park situated within a capital city, with the facility offering visitors opportunity to go on wildlife safari and see buffaloes, lions, giraffes, antelopes and rhinos in their natural habitats against the backdrop of Nairobi's skyscrapers. The park remains one of the most iconic tourist sites in the country. Its location in the city, and, therefore, closer to major installations like the Jomo Kenyatta International Airport and top hotels, makes it easily accessible, offering unmatched experience to both local residents and international tourists. Other tourist attractions in Nairobi are the National Museum, Giraffe Centre, Karen Blixen Museum and Nairobi Arboretum.

Coast

This is the bedrock of Kenya's tourism industry, drawing millions of visitors annually who visit to sample its magnificent beaches, rich Swahili culture and heritage. The major attractions in the region are the sandy beaches. Stretching from Mombasa to Kilifi, Lamu and Kwale counties, the shores are lined with white sand, swaying palm trees, warm waters of the Indian Ocean and a hospitable people. Popular destinations for both local and international tourists include Mombasa, Diani, Nyali,



The sandy beaches of Diani in Kwale County.

Malindi, Watamu, Wasini and Lamu, with visitors getting opportunities to swim, sand bath and kite surf. Other attractions in the region are Fort Jesus in Mombasa, Mombasa and Lamu Old Towns, with the latter being a UNESCO World Heritage Site, Haller Park, Tsavo National Park, Shimba Hills National Reserve and several marine parks. The Government has improved transport connectivity to the Coast, making it easier to access the region by road, railway and air.

Rift Valley

The region is home to iconic tourist attractions such as Lake Nakuru National Park, Hell's Gate National Park, Lake Naivasha, Mt Longonot, Lake Bogoria, Lake Baringo and Maasai Mara National Reserve. These key attractants make the region one of the most important in Kenya's tourism sector. For Maasai Mara, it is famous for the Great Wildebeest Migration, a natural spectacle named the Seventh Wonder of the World. During the migration, the wildebeests, as well as zebras and gazelles, cross from Tanzania's Serengeti into the Mara between July and October, braving crocodileinfested rivers in search of greener pastures. Over the years, the event has been televised live across the world, cementing its status as one of nature's greatest spectacles. The sheer scale of the migration has made the Game Reserve a darling of tourists, researchers and filmmakers, who are eager to witness the drama of survival unfold in the wilderness.

Central

The region offers a mix of magnificent natural parks, colonial era attractions and scenic spots, including the Aberdare and Mt Kenya national parks. Mt Kenya National Park, home to Africa's second-highest peak after Kilimanjaro at 5,199 metres (17,057 ft), is the biggest attractant. The park draws thousands of visitors annually who tour to experience the diverse wildlife. Activities at the park include climbing to Lenana Point, a popular destination for mountain climbers, wildlife safaris featuring elephants, buffaloes and colobus monkeys and birdwatching with over 130 species recorded. Then there is the Thompson Falls in Nyahururu, which plunges at 74 metres (243 feet), sending up a mist that often catches the sunlight to form beautiful rainbows. The waterfall, located on Ewaso Ng'iro River in Laikipia County, is about a four-hour drive in Nairobi, making it accessible

by road or train.

Western

At the heart of the region's tourism is Kakamega Forest, the only tropical rainforest in Kenya. The forest's towering trees offer a vibrant ecosystem where monkeys, butterflies and hundreds of bird species thrive, enabling visitors to have unforgettable experiences whenever they tour. Away from the forest, the Crying Stone in Ileshi along Kakamega-Kisumu Road stands as a striking cultural landmark, with the massive outcrop resembling a human figure shedding tears. The Webuye Falls, located along River Nzoia, offer a serene spot for photography while the Mt Elgon National Park is home to volcanic caves, which its tens of elephants venture inside to mine salt from the walls, a rare spectacle for tourists. Western Kenya is also rich in cultural experiences, with bullfighting among the Isukha and

Idakho communities and traditional circumcision among the Bukususi attracting hundreds of people.

Eastern

The region, comprising of Lower and Upper Eastern, is a mixture of arid lands and lush highlands making it one of the most dynamic in the tourism circuits. At its heart lies Meru National Park, which teem with elephants, lions, cheetahs and rhinos. The film Born Free immortalised the park, making it one of the most enchanting places to visit. Other attractants in the region are the Isiolo National Reserve, where giraffes, ostriches, antelopes and other game animals roam freely. Away from the parks in Lower Eastern, the Akamba people of Machakos, Makueni and Kitui counties are renowned for their beautiful wood carvings and vibrant culture. Key attractions include the Nzambani Rock and Mwingi Game Reserve in Kitui County.

North Eastern

One of the most remarkable destinations in the region is Sibiloi National Park, which is located on the shores of Lake Turkana. The park hosts wildlife such as crocodiles, hippos and antelopes. Turkana, known as the cradle of mankind due to archaeological sites in the area, attracts both historians and ordinary citizens alike. Further, Chalbi Desert's beautiful sand dunes create a surreal landscape that leaves many travellers in awe.

Nyanza

Lake Victoria, one of the largest fresh water bodies in the world, is located in the region, with visitors enjoying fishing, boat rides and breathtaking sunsets over its waters. Besides the lake, Nyanza is rich in history. The Kit Mikayi, a towering rock formation near Kisumu, is steeped in Luo legend and serves as a spiritual site where locals gather for prayer and storytelling. In Homa Bay, Rusinga and Takawiri islands offer unmatched experience, with visitors enjoying fishing and bird watching. The Tom Mboya Mausoleum takes tourists down Kenya's political history, as visitors are told about the life and times of one of Kenya's top politicians. The region also boasts of natural wonders such as Ndere Island National Park, which is home to crocodiles, monitor lizards and diverse bird species. It is a haven for eco-tourism and provides panoramic views of the lake's vast waters. In Migori County, the Thimlich Ohinga ruins stand as a UNESCO World Heritage Site, showcasing architectural ingenuity of early communities. ■



Kenyans during a visit to Giraffe Centre in Nairobi.

Sheghu: Woman who commands the mic, the boardroom and rally track

How Pauline, a Kenyan icon, has redefined voice, vision and velocity

By Lilian Kimeto,
CEO Kenya Yearbook
Editorial Board

In a world where women are often told to choose one path, Shujaa Pauline Sheghu, MPRS, HSC, OGW has chosen all of them and conquered each with unmatched brilliance. For 25 years, she has shaped national narratives in broadcasting, elevated public engagement in corporate communication, and shattered barriers in motorsport, becoming one of Kenya's most dynamic and decorated women.

Voice that captivated the nation

Sheghu's rise to national recognition began at KBC Channel 1, where her eloquence, command of Swahili, and magnetic on-screen presence made her a trusted household name. She became the voice many Kenyans woke up to, learned from, and believed in a role she embraced with integrity and passion.

Strategist behind national communication

Beyond the newsroom, Sheghu's career soared. She transitioned to public service first as Chief Officer of Corporate Communications at Geothermal Development Company (GDC) and later seconded as Director of Communication in the Ministry of Sports, Youth Affairs and Creative Economy in the Cabinet Secretary's office. With her sharp strategic insight, she strengthened communication between institutions and the public, shaping conversations that reached communities across the country.

Educator, mentor and industry builder

Armed with a master's degree in development communication from the University of Nairobi and training from Kenya Institute of Mass Communication (KIMC), Pauline blends academic excellence with practical mastery. As a founding member of the Association of Professional Broadcasters (APB) under the leadership of one of her mentors Ms. Tabitha Mutemi, OGW, she has mentored numerous young



Pauline Sheghu (left) and Linet Ayuko compete in the Safari Rally.

communicators and remains a strong advocate for professional standards and ethical journalism.

A life-changing incident

Sheghu's decision to fully embrace rallying is rooted in a moment of profound danger and courage. One night, while seven months pregnant and fresh from producing the 9pm bulletin at KBC, she was followed by armed carjackers along Uhuru Highway. They blocked her vehicle at the roundabout between Haile Selassie Avenue and Uhuru Highway, brandishing guns. Instinct took over, she sped off, narrowly escaping but eventually losing control of the car. That terrifying moment became a defining turning point. "It pushed me back into rallying," she says. "It taught me courage, sharpened my instincts, and strengthened my confidence behind the wheel." Her rally journey has been punctuated by further trials, A dramatic roll during her first KNRC debut in 2011, A second incident during the Rally Cross in Machakos. Each experience hardened her resolve, deepened her skills, and shaped her fearlessness both on the track and in life.

Conquering WRC Safari Rally/KNRC

Against all odds, Pauline became part of the all-women crew to tackle the WRC Safari Rally/ Kenya National

Rally Championship finishing on the podium three consecutive years (2023, 2024, 2025). Her journey represents courage, resilience, and the limitless potential of Kenyan women in motorsport.

Saluting super co-driver Linet Ayuko

Pauline's success has been a shared victory. She pays heartfelt tribute to her navigator, Linet Ayuko, whose partnership, chemistry, and precision have been key to their podium finishes. "You can't go anywhere in rallying without a navigator who truly clicks with you. Linet has pushed me, encouraged me, and believed in me. She is my super co-driver."

Historic Government



support for women in motorsport

Pauline is part of a historic milestone: For the first time in Kenya's history, the Kenya Kwanza Government, through the Ministry of Sports sponsored a women's motorsport crew for three consecutive years. This groundbreaking support, complementing several forward-thinking corporate sponsors, has positioned Kenya as a champion of gender equality in sports and created new pathways for women in rallying.

Honours that speak to a lifetime of impact

Her excellence has earned national recognition including Head of State Commendation (HSC), Order of the Grand Warrior (OGW), National

Heroes Award, presented by H.E President William Ruto during the Mashujaa Day celebrations through the National Heroes Council. These honors reflect her extraordinary contributions to communication, public service, and women's empowerment.

Gratitude to family, mother and media

Pauline's journey has been anchored by unwavering support from her late father, Mr. Agostino Sheghu (May his soul rest in peace), her dear mother, son and family, who believed in her dreams from the very beginning and have continuously prayed for her safety and success. She also appreciates the media fraternity for amplifying her story, giving visibility to women breaking boundaries in motorsport and leadership.

A life of balance, grace and purpose Beyond the spotlight, Pauline remains grounded as a mother, mentor, professional, and competitor guided by humility and faith. Her story is a reminder that adversity can carve strength, opportunity can create legacy, and courage can build history.

Pauline Sheghu, HSC, OGW A woman of voice. A woman of speed. A woman of courage. A She of All Trade doing it all and doing it with excellence.

TOURISM

NEW CAMPAIGNS

Aggressive marketing, new offerings sustain growth in Kenya’s tourism

Government’s efforts to market Kenya abroad pay off as the tourism sector sustain growth over the years especially after the Covid-19 pandemic

Kenya’s dream of becoming the preferred tourist destination started soon after independence, and the results are evident as we celebrate the 63rd Jamhuri Day.

The sector has demonstrated remarkable growth over the years, with international arrivals hitting over 2.4 million in 2024, exceeding the set targets over the Medium-Term.

The Ministry of Tourism and Wildlife in its Medium Term Expenditure Framework (MTEF) 2026/27-2028/29 released in September this year, noted that in the 2024/2025 fiscal year, the number of tourists rose by 400,000 to stand at 2.42 million.

This was an increase from 2.1 million visitors in 2023/2024 financial year and 1.65 million in 2022/2024.

At the same time, total earnings from the sector have been on the rise, standing at Sh458.2 billion in 2024/2025, an increase from Sh297.3 billion in 2022/2023 and Sh384.35 billion in 2023/2024.

“The steady growth is attributed to destination marketing, improved



Ms Rebecca Miano, the Cabinet Secretary Ministry of Tourism and Wildlife.

access via Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) and new airline routes, diversification of product offerings like Magical Kenya, signature experiences and rise in the average tourism spend from Sh180,000 to Sh189,000,” reads the MTEF report.

The rise in tourism numbers correspond to growth in budgetary allocations for the tourism sector, which have increased from Sh10 billion to Sh12 billion in the 2023/24 financial year.

In 2024/2025 fiscal year, allocations in the sector increased to Sh14.4 billion. It is projected that the sector

will require Sh20.61 billion for the 2026/27 financial year, Sh22.2 billion for the year 2027/2028 and Sh24.5 billion to finance the 2028/2029 expenditure.

President William Ruto, who has been aggressively marketing the country, is today expected to announce new tourism policies that advance the sector. The President has signalled Kenya’s determination in achieving a target of 5 million international visitors by 2027.

“We are expanding our tourism products beyond wildlife, national parks and beaches to include digital



Ms Sylvia Museiya, PS Wildlife.

innovation, sports and conference tourism, and culture are the new areas on offer,” the President said during the opening of the 2025 Great Wildebeest Migration global live coverage, which was done in partnership with China Media Group Africa at the world famous Masai Mara Game Reserve in Narok County .

He said the Government has focused on tourism that enriches both the visitor and the host and transform travellers into ambassadors of the sector for Kenya.

After slumping during the Covid-19 era that started in 2020, the tourism sector has been on an upward trajectory following the implementation of ETA in 2022, according to Economic Survey 2025.

ETA is a digital system that makes it easier for all visitors, including infants and children, to get approval into getting into the country.

Other factors that have contributed to the growth of the sector over the years are aggressive marketing abroad, enhanced tourism product diversification and adoption of digital tools such as smart booking platforms and targeted online promotion.

A report by World Travel and Tourism Council (WTTC) released in June this year projects that by 2035, travel and tourism will contribute Sh1.8 trillion to Kenya’s economy



Mr John Oloituaa, PS Tourism

and support over 2.2 million jobs.

This means that 500,000 new jobs are expected to be created in the sector over the next decade, a clear demonstration of the sector’s role in driving inclusive and sustainable growth. The global tourism body further forecasts that international visitor spending will hit over Sh300 billion in Kenya, a 31 per cent increase from 2019.

The growth, according to the Council, reflects Kenya’s growing appeal on the global travel map, boosted by its natural beauty, cultural heritage, wildlife experiences and improved infrastructure.

Tourism and Wildlife Cabinet Secretary Rebecca Miano notes that the Government has committed to investing Sh200 billion annually to lift up domestic tourism to reach 10 million bed-nights.

Initiatives like Tembea Kenya, driven by transport network the Kenya Tourism Board, are helping to encourage Kenyans to visit the various sites across the country.

This is complemented by the Government’s efforts to improve transport network in key tourists’ regions, including the Coast and Rift Valley. In the strategy, the CS is plotting for an increase of classified beds to 125,000 and accredited beds 215,000. ■

Celebrating 12 years of quality public service with Huduma Kenya

Huduma Kenya is celebrating 12 years of serving Kenyans since its inception in 2013.

Over the period, the institution has worked harder to make Government services accessible and friendlier to all citizens.

Services that were characterised with long queues and would see people shuttled from one office to another are now a simple, one-stop experience that many countries admire.

In the last 12 years, Huduma Kenya has reached many important milestones. Today, there are 59



of Kenyans to access essential Government services close to where they live.

Through Huduma Mashinani, Government services now reach people in remote and marginalised areas, therefore, no one is left behind.

Huduma Kenya has also embraced technology. The Huduma Contact

Huduma Centres across the country, making it easier for millions

Centre and Tele-counselling services have helped improve efficiency, transparency and customer satisfaction. These improvements have earned Huduma Kenya several awards, including international recognition for innovation and excellence in Public Service.

Huduma Kenya continues to grow under the leadership of CEO Ben Kai Chilumo.

His focus on strong partnerships, high service standards and a citizen-first approach has helped the programme remain a trusted and dependable brand.



Huduma Kenya staff serve the public.

Koskei lauds improved integrity in Public Service

There is marked improvement in integrity and governance in Ministries and State entities, the Chief of Staff and Head of Public Service (HoPs) Felix Koskei has said.

Mr Koskei, who was speaking during the 2025 End-Year Public Service Reflection Dinner in Kisumu, noted that 2025 has been the year which the Government has rebuild public sector governance, strengthened weak systems and revived performance culture across its institutions.

He said that 79.39 per cent of public entities achieved clean audit reports under the Zero Fault Audit Campaign, up from less than 35 per cent in previous years. HoPs called for discipline, accountability and the fast-tracking of service delivery across all Ministries, Departments

and Agencies as he awarded public officers who are doing their work diligently. "Tonight's awards are not mere certificates. They are empirical proof of the standards we are establishing as the bare minimum in the Public Service," he said.

Kenya Yearbook Editorial Board (KYEB) Chairperson Wangui Ng'ang'a and Chief Executive Officer Lilian Kimeto are among hundreds of officials who attended the ceremony.

The attendance is part of KYEB's commitment to good governance and Public Service service reforms initiated by the Office of the Chief of Staff and Head of Public Service.

Some of the reforms undertaken by HoPs include nationwide sensitisation on infractions in Public Service, the rewarding of high performers and the sanctioning of officers who breach ethics.

Other reforms are the deepening of the use of platforms such as



Head of Public Service Felix Koskei (inset) in Kisumu during the end-year meeting where top performing public servants were feted.

FOTIMS and ePOMPMIS and over 190 MDAs submitting corruption risk assessment reports to the Ethics and Anti-Corruption Commission.

He added that 34 surcharge cases were filed against officers, with Sh70.5 million pending recovery.

NEW OPENINGS

How food and culture offer new tourism opportunities

Kenya is earning a name in gastronomy, a new form of tourism where food is driving tourism arrivals.

Culinary art, according to Kenya Association of Travel Agents, is now regarded by stakeholders and policy makers as a legitimate form of diplomacy as it combines trade, tradition and innovation to facilitate development across Africa.

Kenya is carving a niche in this new form of tourism. A visit by an international visitor in Kenya is not complete without them sampling sizzling nyama choma (grilled meat).

At the same time, Swahili dishes washed down with kahawa tungu, a unique Swahili espresso that invigorates senses, have become a must have.

Last month, Nairobi hosted a Street Food Festival, where the city's vibrant informal wide menu made up of nyama choma, chapati, ugali and a variety of coastal and seafood was on offer.

This was the sixth edition of a festival that transforms the city into a platform for creative enterprise. Visitors sample foods from across the country while enjoying live performances, artisanal coffee tastings and craft markets. The event also encourages sustainable tourism by spotlighting small food vendors and promoting urban culinary heritage. Tourism and Wildlife Cabinet Secretary Rebecca Miano notes that Kenya is a melting pot of



Participants during the 98th edition of the Kenya Music and Cultural Festival in Eldoret, Uasin Gishu County on Monday.

assorted cultures that provide it with rich experience to share with the rest of the world.

Culture has become another magnet for drawing in domestic and international tourist. The cultural festivals include Tobong'u Lore Lake Turkana Festival, the Maa Cultural Week, the Lamu Cultural Festival and Piny Luo Cultural Festival in Siaya County.

Although cultural festivals celebrate traditions, art, music, dance and culinary heritage of communities, they have immense potential that can boost both tourism sector and the broader economy.

It is as a result of these festivals that both domestic and international visitors have adopted some fashionable traits like the trademark

Maasai shuka, the beaded belt and the colourful bracelets, which identify one with Kenya.

"Cultural festivals are helping to elevate Kenya's status on the global tourism map. With the rise of social media and digital platforms, such events end up attracting worldwide attention, appealing to tourists who may not have considered Kenya as a travel destination," she said.

"As these festivals grow in prominence, they offer Kenya an opportunity to market herself as a multifaceted destination, not just for safaris but way much more."

Kenya is also earning a name because of the artistic graffiti painting on its minibuses. The growing art has evolved into a subculture which is celebrated during the Nganya Awards

Festival. The event blends street culture, vehicle art, performance, music and community energy,

The graffiti which is mostly confined to minibuses in various town has its roots in Nairobi, where it has been transformed into a major event in city's cultural calendar.

Besides the graffiti, some of the one liners crafted on the body of the vehicles are not only wisecrackers but can turn philosophical and deeply religious. To some, the Nganya is a wide moving canvas to counsel, entertain, laugh at the world and even spite foes.

Faces of Presidents, movie stars, iconic artists, football stars and even villains are fair game on the bodies of the moving theatres where everybody is treated equally. ■

Hustler Fund promotes financial sovereignty

As Kenya marks Jamhuri Day today, whose theme is Tourism, Wildlife and Meetings, Incentives, Conferences and Exhibitions (MICE), the role of the Hustler Fund in assisting small businesses in the sector cannot be gainsaid. The sector is among those with high number of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs), which play a critical role in the growth of the industry; from tour operators to artisans, hoteliers, transport providers and event organisers.

These traders are some of the 27 million people who have borrowed about Sh70 billion from the Fund.

Susan Mangeni, the Principal Secretary in the State Department for MSMEs, noted that the businesses are the backbone of every sector and the country's economy. "Through the Hustler Fund, we have opened access to affordable credit, encouraged savings and supported enterprise projects in all the sectors," she said.

She observed that the NYOTA Project, the latest initiative by the Government in the sector, is providing business training and startup grants of Sh50,000 each to some 800,000 youth, a good number of them in the Tourism sector. The NYOTA Project complements the Hustler Fund in nurturing a new generation of entrepreneurs through training, mentorship and provision of seed capital. Since its launch in 2022, the Hustler Fund has not only disbursed loans to businesses and individuals, but also fostered a culture of savings. Kenyans have saved Sh626 million from their loans, an achievement that reflects growing trust in the initiative and a commitment to fostering financial sovereignty.

The Hustler Fund, whose CEO is Henry Tanui, is a key plank of the Bottom-up Economic Transformation Agenda (BETA), helping to push the spirit of Kenya's journey to sovereignty.



Mr Henry Tanui, the new Hustler Fund CEO.

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Today we mark Jamhuri Day, a day on which we celebrate Kenya's attainment of full independence and the birth of the country as a Republic.

Jamhuri Day, commemorated annually on December 12, is a special moment for us to reflect on our journey as a nation.

It is a time we honour the resilience, sacrifices and vision of our forefathers, whose wisdom, courage and devotion has shaped the progress we have made over the years.

Their selfless service transformed Kenya into a Republic; a Sovereign State, enabling the country to chart its own destiny.

Jamhuri Day is, therefore, not only a remembrance of our liberation, but also a celebration of the collective will of Kenyans to continue to advance our country in governance, sports, security, entrepreneurship, health, education and agriculture.

At the Kenya Yearbook Editorial Board (KYEB), we document these advancements and join Kenyans in celebrating national holidays as key pillars of our collective story.

It is our mandate to ensure that the stories of our heroes, institutions and national achievements are recorded for present and future generations to foster a sense of belonging, identity and pride.

Through our publications, including the Kenya Yearbook, AgendaKenya and the Cabinet Series, we document the strides we have made in Health, Governance, ICT, Agriculture and Housing, among others, because of the sovereignty we attained.

Under the Bottom-up Economic Transformation Agenda (BETA), the Government has stepped up investments in key sectors, in particular agriculture, health, MSMEs, ICT and housing.

In agriculture, provision of affordable fertiliser and expansion of irrigation have empowered small-

scale farmers to increase productivity, therefore, boosting food security.

In education, there is increased enrolment in technical training institutions and recruitment of teachers to ensure the smooth rollout of the Competency-Based Curriculum (CBC).

Healthcare remains a priority for the Government, with expanded access through the Social Health Authority (SHA) where transformation agenda over 24 million people have registered, ensuring citizens receive quality care.

Similarly, under the digital transformation agenda, expansion of the National

Optic Fibre Backbone Infrastructure (NOFBI), provision of free public Wi-Fi and construction of digital labs for youth skilling, have enabled increased access to internet and position Kenya

as a technology hub in Africa.

The dream of every family living in a decent place is progressively unfolding, as the Government expands the affordable housing project.

Hundreds of families have not only secured dignity and security through the houses, but the projects have also employed over 300,000 youths.

The strengthening of MSMEs through provision of micro-loans under Hustler Find has created new pathways for employment and innovation, ensuring that the spirit of enterprise complements our sovereignty.

As KYEB, we believe that by documenting these achievements and others in the different sectors, we preserve the memory of our struggles, honour the triumphs of our people and guide the roadmap into the future.

May this Jamhuri Day inspire us to celebrate our togetherness, our diversity and our commitment to our prosperity as a sovereign nation.

Happy Jamhuri Day! ■



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